might result in catastrophic defeat. Now, however, the weak state can directly challenge territorial boundaries, encouraged by the knowledge that its opponent is unlikely to employ the full extent of its military power in response.

Second, nuclear weapons could create diplomatic incentives for a weak, dissatisfied state to engage in destabilizing behavior. A nuclear conflict would have catastrophic human and economic effects;[24] it would also break the nuclear taboo in effect since the end of World War II.[25] The international community is extremely anxious to avoid a nuclear exchange anywhere in the world. Aggressive conventional military behavior that threatens to create a nuclear crisis can attract international attention, including mediation efforts by outside states. Such third-party intervention can result in a territorial settlement superior to any that the weak state could have secured in purely bilateral negotiations with its stronger adversary. Weak, dissatisfied states therefore may have a diplomatic incentive to engage in aggressive conventional military behavior that provokes their adversaries and creates a danger of nuclear confrontation.

It is important to note that proliferation is likely to be emboldening only where both of the criteria that I have specified are satisfied: The proliferating state must be territorially dissatisfied and militarily weak. If the state were satisfied with existing territorial boundaries, it would have no reason to attempt to change them, with or without nuclear weapons. And if the state were strong relative to its primary adversary, it would not need nuclear weapons to facilitate aggressive behavior. It could forcefully challenge existing boundaries even in a purely conventional military environment. Thus proliferation creates incentives for destabilizing behavior by weak, dissatisfied states, but not by those that are militarily strong, territorially satisfied, or both strong and satisfied.

Such provocative behavior by a newly nuclear state would be dangerous. It would invite forceful responses from the state's stronger adversary, which would seek to defeat ongoing aggression and to deter such behavior in the future. Even though neither side would wish resulting conflicts to spiral to the nuclear level, such escalation could occur. For example, the stronger state's retaliatory attack might be more successful than either state anticipated, quickly